BIHAR

THE CASTE CALCULUS

By Amitabh Srivastava



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A NEW MOON BECKONS? CM Nitish and RJD's Tejashwi at the latter's iftar party in Patna, April 22

On May 11, Bihar chief minister Nitish Kumar had a one-on-one meeting with leader of the Opposition Tejashwi Yadav, ostensibly to decide when to hold a statewide caste census in Bihar. But any meeting with the de facto Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) chief raises the political heat in capital Patna, especially since Nitish's Janata Dal (United) and alliance partner BJP have been having a testy time of late.

Tejashwi later told the media not to attach any political meaning to the tete-a-tete but the fact that no other leader was present—not even any bureaucrat to explain the nitty-gritty of a census—only fanned speculation about a political realignment. The two former allies have been at loggerheads since July 2017 when Nitish dumped the RJD and Congress and joined hands with the BJP to form a new government. But the ice seems to have melted after April 22 when Nitish dropped in at an iftar at the residence of Rabri Devi, Tejashwi's mother. They have since had two more meetings, including the one on May 11.

That this thaw could be just a way for Nitish to shore up his political relevance—and bargaining power with the BJP—is another likelihood observers grant. After all, he has a history of waxing and waning on the RJD at strategic points. Nor does it harm Tejashwi to play along, with caste as the winning logic. On May 16, five days after their meeting, Nitish announced that an all-party meeting would be called on the caste census. "There will be no delays," he said, promising "a cabinet decision" on moving forward after all inputs were received.

CM NITISH SAYS "THERE WILL BE NO MORE DELAYS" FOR THE CASTE CENSUS. THIS MAY SEE A RESURGENCE OF THE REGIONAL PARTIES; IT WILL WORRY THE BJP

It may be a political gambit but the two leaders have clear arguments for a caste census in Bihar. As it would do elsewhere in India if conducted, it will enable a detailed enumeration of OBCs (Other Backward Classes) and help identify sections that remain off the government's social welfare radar or have not fully got their due share of benefits. It will quantify the sundry layers of OBC communities, just as it does for Scheduled Castes and Tribes in the national census. But OBC numbers are a hot potato. They bump up against the vexed issue of reservations—and the Supreme Court cap of a cumulative 50 per cent. The real OBC population numbers could cast questions on the very logic of that ceiling. No wonder successive regimes at the Centre have dithered. In the 2011 national census, OBC numbers were kept off the official list—and remain a secret. The Modi government mulled over having OBCs counted in the 2021 iteration, and finally opted not to go down that route, as Union MoS for home Nityanand Rai clarified to the Lok Sabha in July 2021.

For Nitish, who is credited with getting state benefits to the most marginalised among the OBCs and SCs (categorised as the extremely backward classes or EBCs or Mahadalits in Bihar), it's just the theme that could galvanise his core vote base. Which is exactly what the BJP fears—a new demographic exercise that could facilitate the resurgence of parties like the RJD and JD(U) which have OBCs as their core voters. With less than two years to go before the next Lok Sabha election, the BJP is likely to put up some voluble resistance to the idea—but without seeming to be anti-welfare. ■